had done so much to drag Shuja back out of retirement, ever actually met the man he had been championing for so long.

Shuja had now spent thirty years in exile in Ludhiana – half his life – but had never for a minute given up hope of returning home and ruling the country he regarded as given to him to rule by God. Recently, he had lost his remarkable wife, the formidable Wa'fa Begum, and, to add to the pain, fanatical Sikh *akalis* almost immediately desecrated the tomb he built for her at the dargah [shrine] of Sirhind.[121]

On 14 July 1838 Macnaghten arrived in Ludhiana, relieved finally to have reached an agreement with Ranjit Singh. Shuja had been kept briefed by his own network of spies and informers, and he was all too aware that he was being treated as a puppet – or a *mooli*, a radish, as the Afghans call it. He was especially humiliated that the action for which he had been waiting three decades had finally been arranged behind his back without even the most cursory reference to him as to how it would be executed. Nor was he at all happy about paying any tribute to Ranjit Singh, the man who had tortured his son and stolen his most valuable possession, even if in the treaty the tribute was disguised as a 'subsidy'.

In the *Jangnama*, the first Afghan epic poem to be written about the British invasion, this meeting between the British and Shah Shuja is imagined as one where Macnaghten ('His heart had no transparency – only smoke') and Burnes ('that seditious man') used their devilish charms and flattery to overcome the reservations of the Shah ('Shuja the Vile') about returning to Afghanistan as a British puppet:

> They said: 'O Shah, we are your servants!
> We bow down humbly before your command.'
>
> When the Shah listened to their stories
> The key to the lock of speech did appear.
>
> He said to them: 'O my companions!
> Let us start trouble within the Amir's kingdom.
>
> I will take his country and crown
> I will place a noose around his neck.
>
> Where can he escape the flash of my sword?
> He will certainly give up his throne to me.
>
> Then the kingdom of Kabul will immediately